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SECTOR AT A GLANCE 05

Rural: ODF and Toilet Infrastructure in India

WASH in India

DRAFT

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WASH IN INDIA

The '**Sector-at-a-Glance**' provides an easy-to-read overview and basic understanding of a sector, sub-sector, or thematic area. The facts and insights on the sector are supported by relevant data and best practices from credible government and multilateral sources. The document covers the structure, key trends, opportunities and challenges, government initiatives, and the way forward for the sector.

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Overview

Ending open defecation in rural India has been a key focus for both SBM-G in 2014 and SBM-G 2.0 in 2021. While SBM-G focused on universal toilet coverage, SBM-G 2.0 builds on this and strives to achieve universal Open-Defecation Free Plus (ODF+) status in all rural habitations.

This involves ensuring universal access to functioning toilets (within households, communities, and schools), behaviour change to ensure ongoing usage of toilets, and ensuring the safe disposal of liquid and solid waste.

These focused efforts have led to significant gains: nearly 5.08 lakh villages are now reported ODF+, more than 90% of individuals having access to a toilet report using it, and surveys have revealed that 99.6% of public toilets have access to water to enable ongoing use.¹

However, there remain key challenges. Toilet coverage in schools remains low, toilet infrastructure requires ongoing maintenance and financial support for this, and social norms still deter universal usage.

Going forward, it will be important to invest in targeted interventions to improve sanitation infrastructure in schools, provide support for the maintenance of toilet infrastructure, and continue to engage in localized behavioural programs to shift norms and habits and ensure universal usage.

Doing this will ensure that health, education, economic productivity, and gender equity benefits get fully realized for hundreds of millions of Indians.

Figure 1: Key urban waste management statistics



Source: MoSPI, Multiple Indicator Survey of Indi 2020-21, 2023; Ministry of Jal Shakti, India Achieves Major Sanitation Milestone As 75% Villages Are Now ODF Plus under Swachh Bharat Mission - Grameen, 2023; Ministry of Jal Shakti, SBM-G dashboard, accessed December 2023

Note: An ODF Plus village is one which has sustained its Open Defecation Free (ODF) status along with implementing either solid or liquid waste management systems.

¹ Ministry of Jal Shakti, Toilets Build Under Swachh Bharat Mission, 2022

Key trends

This section dives deeper into India's rural toilet and ODF+ ecosystem, and covers:

1. Household Toilet Coverage
2. Toilet Operation & Maintenance
3. Capacity Building, Behaviour Change, and Usage
4. School Toilets

Household Toilet Coverage

Household toilet coverage has increased rapidly after the launch of SBM (G) in 2014. There have been significant improvements in access and utilisation, with marked benefits for citizens, particularly for the safety and health of women and girls.

A rapid increase in household toilets constructed:

As of June 2023, according to the SBM-G 2.0 statistics, close to 11.2 crore household toilets have been constructed in rural India alongside over 2.3 lakh community sanitary complexes.²

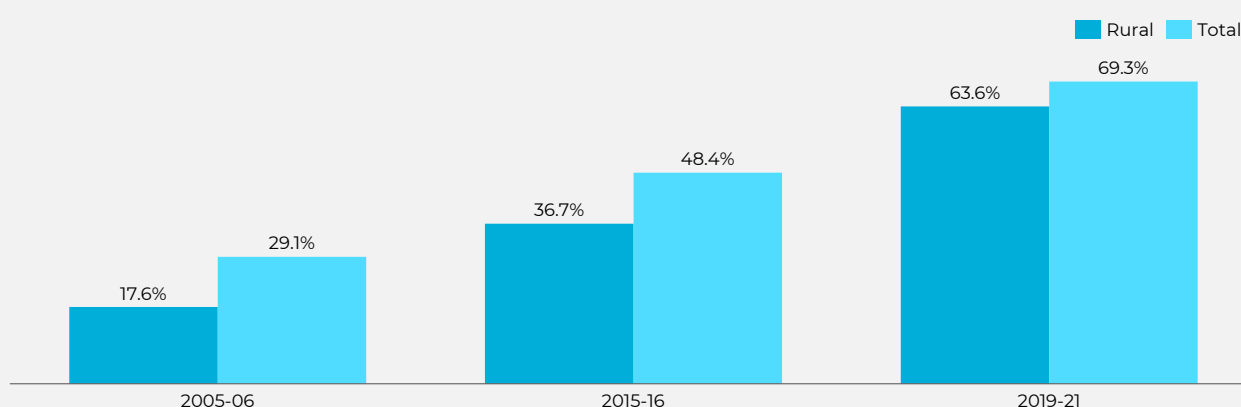
A very large proportion of rural households have access to toilet facilities:

As per the NFHS survey from 2021, 76-79% of rural households had access to a toilet facility.³ More recent government data, based on rapid state-level surveys, shows that several states have between 93%-99% rural sanitation coverage.⁴

Significant reduction in women afraid of contracting health infections while defecating, and improvement in their safety outcomes:

93% of women reported being no longer afraid of contracting health infections while defecating as opposed to 15% of women who reported feeling so before having access to a private toilet.⁵

Figure 2: Share of rural households with access to an improved (not shared) toilet facility in India (2005-06 to 2019-21)



Source: Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, National Family Health Survey-5 (2019-21), 2021; Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, National Family Health Survey-3 (2015-16), 2017; Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, National Family Health Survey-3 (2005-06), 2007

² Ministry of Jal Shakti, Swachh Bharat Mission (Grameen) 2.0, 2023

³ Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, National Family Health Survey, 2019-2021 (lower limit); Ministry of Statistics & Programme Implementation, Multiple Indicators Survey in India, 2020-2021 (upper limit); (Note: Multiple Indicators Survey reports % of households reporting access by majority of household members)

⁴ Ministry of Jal Shakti, Press Release, March 2023

⁵ Ministry of Jal Shakti, Access to toilets and the safety, convenience and self respect of women in rural India, 2020

Toilet Operation & Maintenance

Toilet O&M includes the ongoing upkeep of household, community, and public toilets. Public toilets serve floating populations in public places such as markets, bus stands, railway stations, etc., and hence have higher requirements for O&M.

Utilization rate of toilets by households is high:

Among households having access to latrines, ~95% of males and ~96% of females in rural areas used latrines regularly, reflecting a negligible gender gap in use.⁶ As per the National Annual Rural Sanitation Survey 2019-2020, ~90% of people who had access to toilets were using toilets always.⁷

Availability of water in public toilets:

99.6% of public toilets had water available for toilet use, without any significant differences between water availability in public toilets of ODF and non-ODF village categories.⁸

Capacity Building & Behaviour Change

A key focus within SBM-G 2.0 was sustained behaviour change related to the usage of toilets and capacity building of both citizens and sanitation workers to safely manage solid and liquid waste. This has led to significant progress as measured through the ODF+ status of villages and the behaviour change of various actors.

A rapid increase in the number of ODF+ villages:

As of December 2023, according to the SBM-G 2.0 statistics, close to 5.08 lakh villages have achieved ODF+ status of a total of 5.9 lakh villages in the country.⁹

Women are increasingly beginning to use household and community toilets:

Before gaining access to household toilets or community toilets, women and girls would have to think carefully about when they could defecate. Most women would have to ensure they went in the morning, often before sunrise or early evening. After gaining access to private toilets, women who felt comfortable going to the toilet at any time increased from 11% to 46%.¹⁰

Foot soldiers or 'Swacchagrahis' have played a central role in behaviour change:

'Swacchagrahis', skilled in community approaches, worked closely with the people at the village level, bringing about required behaviour change. Training content aligned to the specific roles and responsibilities of key stakeholders helped build their competencies and skills, enhancing their ability to integrate communication interventions with the overall program implementation.¹¹

⁶ Ministry of Statistics & Programme Implementation, National Sample Survey 76th Round, 2018

⁷ Ministry of Jal Shakti, National Annual Rural Sanitation Survey, 2019-2020

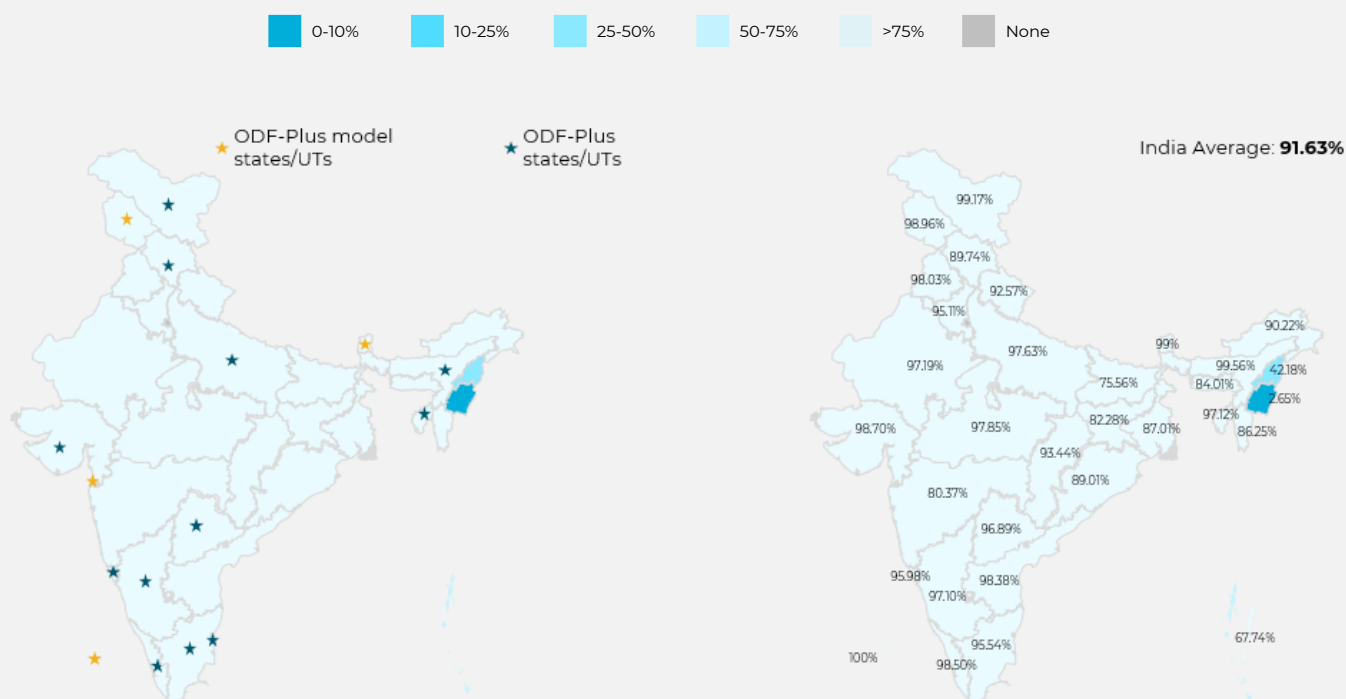
⁸ Ministry of Jal Shakti, National Annual Rural Sanitation Survey, 2019-2020

⁹ Ministry of Jal Shakti, Dashboard, Accessed 20th December 2023

¹⁰ Ministry of Jal Shakti, Access to toilets and the safety, convenience and self-respect of women in rural India, 2020

¹¹ Ministry of Jal Shakti, Manual: IEC for ODF Plus, 2021

Figure 3: Share of villages declared ODF+ by state and UT (2023)



Source: Ministry of Jal Shakti, SBM-G dashboard, accessed December 2023

School Toilets

Toilet infrastructure in schools is crucial for promoting hygiene, ensuring privacy, and creating a safe and inclusive learning environment. School toilets have specific requirements for both girls and boys, which vary based on whether the toilets are installed in primary or secondary schools.

Gender-segregated toilets in all government schools:

The Ministry of Human Resource Development undertook the Swachh Vidyalaya initiative in 2014 to provide separate toilets for girls and boys in all Government schools within one year under the Swachh Bharat Abhiyan. The target fixed under the initiative was achieved with the construction/reconstruction of 4.2 lakh toilets in 2.6 lakh primary and secondary schools.¹² As per the National Annual Rural Sanitation Survey 2019-2020, 99.3% of school toilets in rural India were functional.¹³

Behaviour changes in schools:

Partnerships with civil society organizations and corporations have helped create behaviour change amongst children in schools. The Swacch Vidyalaya Puraskar initiative aims to recognize and celebrate excellence in Government schools, with awards and cash incentives for schools successfully fulfilling the mandate of the Swachh Vidyalaya campaign.¹⁴

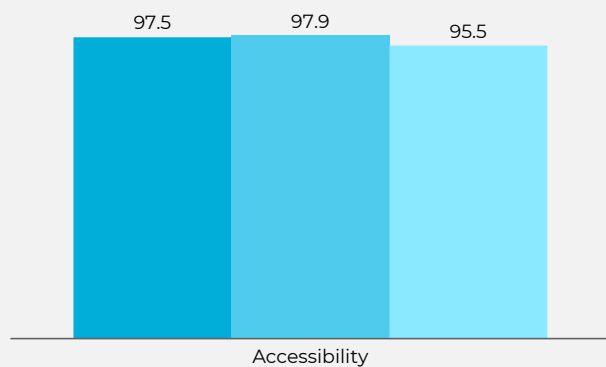
Figure 4: Share of schools with functional toilet access by village category (2019-20)

¹² Ministry of Education, Press Information Bureau: Swachh Vidyalaya Initiative to Ensure Toilets in All Government Schools, 2018

¹³ Ministry of Jal Shakti, National Annual Rural Sanitation Survey, 2019-2020

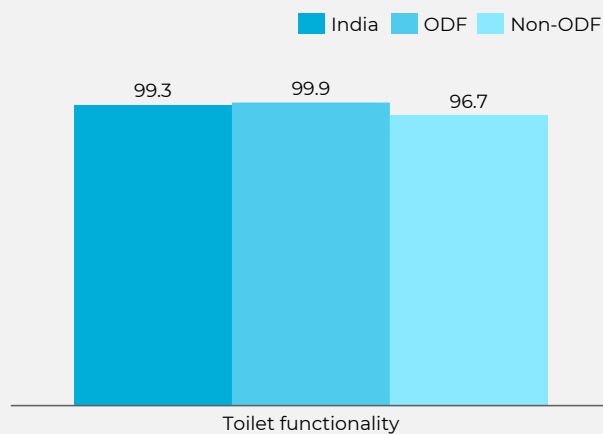
¹⁴ Department of School Education and Literacy, Press Information Bureau: Swacchta Vidyalaya initiative, 2016

School with toilet access by village category (%)



Base: All villages with schools – 5955

Functional status of toilet by village category (%)



Base: All school toilets observed successfully – 5807

Source: Ministry of Jal Shakti, National Annual Rural Sanitation Survey (NARSS), Round-3, 2019-20, 2020

Opportunities and challenges

Opportunities

This section highlights the outcomes policymakers can achieve by adopting universal toilet infrastructure coverage in rural India. These revolve primarily around greater health and education-related outcomes, higher workforce productivity, and fostering gender equity.



Improvement in health outcomes:

The lack of proper sanitation facilities contributes to the spread of diarrheal and waterborne diseases, posing a severe health risk in rural India.¹⁵ By providing access to hygienic sanitation facilities and promoting regular handwashing practices, disease transmission can be significantly reduced, enhancing health outcomes and improving the overall well-being of rural communities.¹⁶



Higher economic productivity:

With improved sanitation facilities, there is a decrease in disease cases related to poor hygiene practices, leading to fewer medical expenses and a healthier workforce.¹⁷ Additionally, the value of time savings is significant due to the convenience of having a toilet close by, leading to increased efficiency in daily activities.¹⁸



Greater gender equity and safety:

Women without access to toilets often face safety risks when they need to defecate in the open, especially during nighttime. The lack of privacy exposes them to the danger of sexual assault, robbery, and attacks by vermin. Thus, improved toilet infrastructure provides women with safe and private sanitation options that foster their dignity, security, and active participation in society.¹⁹



Improvement in education outcomes:

Access to better toilet facilities in schools and educational institutions can positively impact student attendance, learning outcomes, and overall education standards.²⁰

Challenges

This section highlights some of the major challenges and constraints affecting universal toilet coverage in rural India. Resolving these is essential to ensure ongoing use and sustaining ODF+ statuses of villages.



Inadequate infrastructural quality and limited water availability:

As per SBM (G) 1.0 guidelines, poor quality of toilets has been highlighted as one of the major complaints within earlier programs.²¹ There is also a need for ensuring the availability of water for toilet usage within households- ~27% of households with access to their own/shared toilet either had to rely on water from outside household premises or did not have access to water for toilet usage at all.²² It will be important to ensure that these issues remain addressed going forward.

¹⁵ UNICEF, Water, sanitation and hygiene, accessed 2023

¹⁶ UNICEF, Sanitation, accessed 2023

¹⁷ UNICEF, Financial and Economic Impacts of the Swachh Bharat Mission in India, 2018

¹⁸ UNICEF, Financial and Economic Impacts of the Swachh Bharat Mission in India, 2018

¹⁹ WeAreWater Foundation, Toilets To Provide Freedom, Health And Dignity To Women, 2017

²⁰ UNICEF, Clean India - Clean schools, accessed 2023

²¹ Ministry of Jal Shakti, Guidelines for Swachh Bharat Mission (Gramin), 2017

²² Ministry of Jal Shakti, National Annual Rural Sanitation Survey, 2019-2020



Limited maintenance and upkeep efforts:

Improper maintenance can render built toilet infrastructure, especially the substructure, ineffective and potentially contaminate groundwater resources, affecting drinking water supplies. Thus, periodic pit emptying and clearing of septic tanks is central to ensuring the usability of the toilets.²³ The O&M of shared toilet facilities often pose challenges. Since these facilities are public property, users fail to maintain it with the same care as with individual toilets.²⁴



Sub-optimal beliefs and norms related to toilet usage:

Societal attitudes and norms limit the uptake and usage of toilets in rural India. Even in villages with adequate toilet access, open defecation is still prevalent due to myths and misconceptions. Additionally, toilets are sometimes constructed at a distance from households, which can affect their usability, especially for young children, the elderly, some women, and people with disabilities. Continued engagement in these social norms is critical to ensuring sustained ODF status in all communities across India.²⁵



Low toilet coverage in schools:

As per the National Annual Rural Sanitation Survey 2019-2020, in ODF villages, there was only one functional toilet for every 68 male students and 63 female students. In non-ODF villages, the numbers were 92 male students and 90 female students per functional toilet.²⁶ The toilet seat-to-student ratio was 89 and 137 for common toilets for ODF and non-ODF villages, respectively.²⁷ This falls below the recommended ratio of one unit for every 40 students, as advised by the Swachh Bharat Swachh Vidyalaya Mission.²⁸

²³ Ministry of Jal Shakti, Toolkit for District level officials on Faecal sludge management, 2021

²⁴ Ministry of Rural Development, Establishment and Management of Community Sanitary Complexes in Rural Areas: A handbook, 2011

²⁵ Ministry of Jal Shakti, Manual: IEC for ODF Plus, 2021

²⁶ Ministry of Jal Shakti, National Annual Rural Sanitation Survey, 2019-2020

²⁷ Ministry of Jal Shakti, National Annual Rural Sanitation Survey, 2019-2020

²⁸ Ministry of Education, Swachh Bharat Swachh Vidyalaya, accessed April 2023

Institutional framework and policy landscape –

Key ministries and departments

This section highlights the major central government bodies and national-level institutions that oversee toilet infrastructure and related practices in rural India.



Ministry of Jal Shakti²⁹

The Ministry is responsible for the implementation of the Swachh Bharat Mission-Grameen 2.0. It also houses the Department of Drinking Water and Sanitation (DDWS) and works towards causes related to rural sanitation, including sustaining the sanitation behaviour change that has been achieved under the Swachh Bharat Mission Grameen and increasing access to solid and liquid waste management.



Ministry of Panchayati Raj³⁰

The Ministry is responsible for all matters related to the Panchayati Raj and Panchayati Raj Institutions in rural areas. It collaborates with the Ministry of Jal Shakti to implement rural sanitation initiatives.

Major policies and programs

This section highlights existing policies related to toilet infrastructure in rural India and related practices and their most prominent features. A more comprehensive list of policies is provided in the policy repository of the NITI for States platform.



Swachh Bharat Mission-Grameen 2.0³¹

The second phase of SBM(G) aims to sustain the ODF status of villages and to improve the levels of cleanliness in rural areas by:

- Promoting behaviour change campaigns to promote sustained toilet usage and better sanitation practices
- Supporting the construction of individual household toilets, community sanitary complexes, and retrofitting
- Promoting the adoption of low-cost technologies for O&M of toilets

²⁹ Ministry of Jal Shakti, Department of Drinking Water and Sanitation, Accessed December 2023

³⁰ Ministry of Panchayati Raj, Joint Advisory on Swachh Bharat Mission-Grameen (SBM-G) Phase II, accessed December 2023

³¹ Ministry of Jal Shakti, Swachh Bharat Grameen 2.0, 2022

Way forward

Considerable progress has been made in rural toilet coverage over the last few years and India is extremely well positioned to achieve universal ODF+ status in the near future. This will ensure significantly better health, gender equity, and economic productivity outcomes, but also greater dignity for hundreds of millions of Indians.

The building blocks are all in place and concerted efforts on a few themes would enable greater progress:

 Ensuring high-quality school toilet infrastructure	Having a dedicated focus to improve school toilet infrastructure both in terms of toilet:student ratios and also the design of toilets to ensure use by children with disabilities, menstruating females, and other groups facing access or quality challenges.
 Enabling financially sustainable operations and maintenance	Well-designed financing programs are necessary to support the periodic maintenance of household level, community, and school toilets and also provide targeted assistance for pit emptying as these tend to be impediments to ongoing usage.
 Investing in IEC programming	Behaviour change programs will remain critical for ensuring that toilet usage is sustained for all segments of users.
 Ensuring climate- and flood-resilience	Ensuring that rural toilet infrastructure is climate- and flood-resilient will be very critical going forward. Climate change is likely to show up as either floods or droughts in rural India and states should create advanced models of which areas are likely to be most affected and then develop toilet adaptation plans to ensure that citizens keep using their toilets even in the face of these pressures. Partnerships with expert organizations can help states carry out this planning rigorously and scientifically will enable such planning.

Recommended readings

Ministry of Jal Shakti, UNICEF, Bill and Melinda Gates Foundation, Sambodhi. (2021). *Access to toilets and the safety, convenience and self-respect of rural women*

<https://swachhbharatmission.gov.in/sbmcms/writereaddata/Portal/Images/pdf/Safety-security-and-dignity-of-women.pdf>

Ministry of Jal Shakti. (2017). *Guidelines for Swachh Bharat Mission (Gramin)*

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Ministry of Jal Shakti. (2021). *Toolkit for District level officials on Faecal sludge management.*

<https://swachhbharatmission.gov.in/sbmcms/writereaddata/Portal/Images/pdf/FirstsetFSMtoolkit.pdf>



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